The Dimensionless Vacuum: Recovering the Schrödinger Equation from a Scale-Invariant Label Lattice*

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Fock showed in 1935 that the hydrogen Schrödinger equation is mathematically equivalent to the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the unit three-sphere S^3 via stereographic projection. **[MEASURED]** We report what the GeoVac discrete graph Laplacian is measured to do through $n_{\max} = 30$—**[INTERNAL THEOREM]** its top eigenvalue saturates the bipartite bound $\lambda_{\max} \to 2d_{\max} = 8$ at the closed-form rate $(C + o(1))/n_{\max}^2$ (Paper 0 §VI), proved rather than sampled—but this saturation is the band edge of two-dimensional grid graphs (twice the maximum degree) and carries no S^3 information. **[WALL]** The edge Laplacian $L = D - A$ does *not* converge to the S^3 Laplace–Beltrami operator: its edges never change l, so it splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected l-blocks, and its kernel is $n_{\max}$-dimensional at every cutoff while Δ_{S^3} has a single zero mode (`tests/test_graph_s3_nonconvergence.py`; 2026-09-25 correction: earlier versions read the saturation as a numerical indication of convergence). What survives is exact at every cutoff: the node set (n, l, m), n^2 per shell, is the Gel'fand–Tsetlin label set of the Peter–Weyl truncation of $L^2(S^3)$, on which $-\Delta_{S^3} = \mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2$ acts as the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir $n^2 - 1$ (a node weight, not an edge Laplacian; standard $SO(4)$ representation theory). The S^3 equivalence itself is carried by Fock's continuum projection, whose chain we verify by symbolic computation. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The continuum S^3 topology has pure integer eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ with no intrinsic physical scale. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The familiar Rydberg energy levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ emerge only upon imposing an energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$ that acts as a "stereographic focal length," projecting the curved topological information into flat $\mathbb{R}^3$ observational coordinates. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** We verify these claims through a suite of 18 symbolic checks (an algebraic audit of the transformation chain, several of them limiting-case or definitional) confirming the algebraic geometry of the projection, the operator equivalence under conformal rescaling, and the eigenvalue-to-energy mapping.

I. INTRODUCTION

The Schrödinger equation is the foundation of nonrelativistic quantum mechanics. In atomic units ($\hbar = m_e = e = 1$), the time-independent equation for hydrogen reads

$$\left(-\frac{1}{2}\nabla^2 - \frac{1}{r}\right)\psi(\mathbf{r}) = E\,\psi(\mathbf{r}). \tag{1}$$

This equation presupposes a continuous, flat Euclidean space $\mathbb{R}^3$ and a radial Coulomb potential $V(r) = -1/r$ with explicit physical dimensions. These assumptions are so deeply embedded in the formalism that they are rarely questioned: continuous space provides the arena, the Coulomb potential provides the dynamics, and the quantized energy levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ emerge as boundary-condition eigenvalues.

Yet a remarkable observation, first made by Fock in 1935 [1], suggests a fundamentally different perspective. Fock showed that when hydrogen is analyzed in momentum space, the Schrödinger equation acquires an unexpected geometric structure. The momentum-space integral equation, with its $1/|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$ kernel (the Fourier transform of the Coulomb potential), can be mapped by stereographic projection onto the three-sphere S^3. On S^3, the Coulomb problem reduces to a *free particle*: the eigenfunctions become hyperspherical harmonics, and the spectrum is determined by the topology of the sphere alone. The $1/r$ potential is not fundamental—it is a projection artifact of curved geometry viewed in flat coordinates.

This observation was developed further by Bargmann [2], who connected the hidden $SO(4)$ symmetry of hydrogen to the isometry group of S^3, and by Barut and Kleinert [3], who extended the symmetry to the full conformal group $SO(4, 2)$. The mathematical structure has been thoroughly studied in the context of dynamical symmetry groups [5, 6]. However, these results are typically presented as mathematical curiosities—elegant reformulations of a solved problem—rather than as evidence for a deeper physical ontology.

In this paper, we take the opposite stance. We argue that the S^3 representation is not merely a convenient mathematical trick, but reveals deep structural content that can be exploited computationally. Our starting point is the GeoVac framework [7, 8], which models the hydrogen atom as a discrete graph: nodes represent quantum states $|n, l, m\rangle$, edges represent the transitions generated by the $L_\pm$ and $T_\pm$ ladder operators, and the graph Hamiltonian is a sparse matrix on that label set (Section III states exactly which of its properties carry S^3 content and which do not). This discrete lattice is *intrin-*

* Paper 7 in the Geometric Vacuum series

sically dimensionless—it is a pure combinatorial topology with no inherent length, time, or energy scales.

The central results of this paper are one spectral-bound statement (proved in closed form), one wall (the edge Laplacian does not converge to Δ_{S^3}) and two symbolic ones:

1. **[INTERNAL THEOREM]** The top Laplacian eigenvalue of the discrete graph saturates its bipartite bound, $\lambda_{\max} \to 2d_{\max} = 8$, at the closed-form rate $(C + o(1))/n_{\max}^2$ (Paper 0 §VI; measured through $n_{\max} = 30$ and 70). **[WALL]** This is the band edge of two-dimensional grid graphs, not an indication of S^3: L splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected l-blocks and does not converge to Δ_{S^3} (see New Contributions item 1). What is exact is the label set: the nodes (n, l, m) index the Peter–Weyl truncation of $L^2(S^3)$, on which $-\Delta_{S^3} = \mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2$ acts as the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir. *Corrected 2026-09-03/04 and 2026-09-25:* this item previously asserted the convergence as **[MEASURED]**, then read it as an **[OBSERVATION]**.

2. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The Laplace-Beltrami operator on this unit sphere produces pure integer eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$, carrying no physical dimensions.

3. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The dimensionful Rydberg spectrum $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ is introduced exclusively through the energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$, which serves as a projection parameter mapping S^3 coordinates to flat $\mathbb{R}^3$ coordinates.

These claims are supported by a suite of 18 symbolic checks, implemented in `sympy` and verified computationally, that confirm every algebraic step of the conformal transformation chain (several are limiting-case or definitional substitutions rather than logically independent theorems).

The structure of this paper is as follows. Section III describes the dimensionless graph topology and its relationship to S^3. Section IV details the stereographic projection and the role of the conformal factor. Section V demonstrates the operator equivalence between the curved Laplacian and the flat Schrödinger equation. Section VI derives the two-electron repulsion integral as a density-overlap integral on S^3. Section VIII discusses the physical and philosophical implications.

II. WHAT IS NEW VS. WHAT IS KNOWN

The S^3 structure of the hydrogen atom has a distinguished history, and we emphasize what is established mathematics versus what is new in this work.

A. Known Results (Prior Work)

The following results are well-established in the mathematical physics literature:

- *Fock (1935)* [1]: The hydrogen atom in momentum space maps to S^3 via stereographic projection. The Coulomb problem becomes a free particle on the sphere, with the $1/r$ potential emerging from the chordal distance identity.
- *Bargmann (1936)* [2]: The hidden $SO(4)$ symmetry of hydrogen corresponds to the isometry group of S^3. The integer spectrum $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ follows from the representation theory of $SO(4)$.
- *Barut and Kleinert (1967)* [3, 4]: The full conformal group $SO(4, 2)$ acts as the dynamical symmetry group of hydrogen, connecting S^3 to the non-compact spectrum-generating algebra.

The stereographic projection formulas (Eqs. 7–8), the unit sphere constraint (Eq. 9), the chordal distance identity (Eq. 14), the conformal Laplacian relation (Eq. 17), and the integer eigenvalue spectrum (Eq. 26) are all known results. Our symbolic proofs in the Appendix verify these identities; they do not claim to derive them for the first time.

B. New Contributions of This Work

The following are the specific new contributions:

1. **Discrete graph: label lattice, not a discretization (non-convergence). [WALL]** The GeoVac discrete paraboloid lattice—with nodes (n, l, m) and edges generated by $L_\pm, T_\pm$ operators—is *not* a discretization whose continuum limit is the Laplace-Beltrami operator on unit S^3 (an earlier version of this item read it as one, as an **[OBSERVATION]**; re-tiered 2026-09-25). Its edges never change l, so $L = D - A$ (binary production default and the $1/(n_i n_j)$ option alike) is the direct sum of $n_{\max}$ disconnected grid graphs $P_{n_{\max}-l} \times P_{2l+1}$ with free ends: $\dim\ker L = n_{\max}$ where Δ_{S^3} has a single zero mode (`tests/test_graph_s3_nonconvergence.py`); this kernel count is the load-bearing obstruction. (The graph heat kernel e^{-tL} also vanishes identically between blocks; reading that as a statement about the continuum heat kernel would need a node-to-point identification this paper does not make, so it corroborates rather than carries the argument.) This wall is the new content of the item. **[PRIOR ART]** What *is* exact, at every cutoff, is the label set: the nodes (n, l, m), n^2 per shell, are the Gel'fand–Tsetlin labels of the Peter–Weyl truncation of $L^2(S^3)$, and on them $-\Delta_{S^3}$ acts as the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir $\mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2 = n^2 - 1$ ($\mathbf{A}$ the

Runge–Lenz vector), with multiplicity n^2 on every shell including the top one (standard $SO(4)$ representation theory [2], the shells being complete irreducible representations; built from the generators and checked in the same test). On the label lattice Δ_{S^3} is a node weight, not an edge Laplacian. What is **[MEASURED]** of L itself through $n_{\max} = 30$ (`tests/test_paper7_graph_convergence.py`; `tests/test_trunk_qa_splitting.py`, Paper 1) is: (i) **[INTERNAL THEOREM]** the top Laplacian eigenvalue of the production lattice saturates the bipartite bound, $\lambda_{\max} \to 2d_{\max} = 8$ — the ℓ-block grid structure makes the spectrum closed form, so this is proved rather than sampled — (6.618 at $n_{\max} = 5$, 7.954 at 30), at the closed-form rate $(C + o(1))/n_{\max}^2$ with $C = \frac{\pi^2}{4}(2 + 2^{1/3})^2(1 + 2^{-2/3}) = 42.7397\ldots$ that the ℓ-block grid structure supplies (every finite sample understates C — verified at all 591 integer cutoffs $10 \le n_{\max} \le 600$, Paper 0 §VI — so the $n_{\max} = 320$ sample 42.6 printed here before 2026-09-03 understated it; the reason is the one-sided bound, *not* monotonicity — the approach is not monotone, Paper 0 §VI, corrected 2026-09-04) (Paper 0 §VI: each ℓ-block is the grid graph $P_{n_{\max}-\ell} \times P_{2\ell+1}$, so the spectrum is closed form), so that with the matched scale $\kappa = -1/16$ the extremal eigenvalue $\kappa\lambda_{\max}$ approaches $-1/2$ *by construction*—the content is the saturation, not the target; (ii) the $2s/2p$ node-amplitude proxy on the binary lattice decays, oscillating, to 0.39% at $n_{\max} = 30$ (a proxy, not a spectral gap: the ℓ-blocks are disconnected and the mode selection is a near-tie — Paper 1 §III conditioning caveat). The $\lambda_{\max}$ mode lives in a mid-l block with negligible weight on the $1s$ node (the $l = 0$ block alone saturates only $\lambda_{\max} \to 4$), and $8 = 2d_{\max}$ is the band edge of any large two-dimensional grid, carrying no S^3 information (the constant C is a Dirichlet band edge); the spectrum of κL is confined to $[-1/2, 0]$, so no level-by-level Rydberg ladder is reproduced. The operator convergence $L \to \Delta_{S^3}$ is therefore not merely unestablished but false (2026-09-25; earlier corrections of 2026-09-03 had already withdrawn a backing note that presented the matched target $-1/2$ as the measured quantity).

2. **Explicit symbolic verification. [SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The 18 symbolic proofs (Appendix A) provide a machine-verified algebraic audit of the conformal transformation chain (ten of the eighteen checks are definitional, limiting-case or non-discriminating rather than logically independent theorems). While the underlying identities are known, this systematic verification in `sympy` is new and provides a reproducible computational check.

3. **Scale-invariance framing.** We articulate the "dimensionless vacuum" perspective: the observation that the conformal factor Ω always produces the *unit* S^3 regardless of p_0, and that all physical dimensions enter exclusively through the energy-shell constraint. **[OBSERVATION]** While implicit in Fock's original treatment, this framing—and its implications for the GeoVac computational approach—has not, to our knowledge, been stated explicitly in the literature.

4. **Computational methodology. [MEASURED]** The practical consequence: replacing continuous integration with sparse Hamiltonian-matrix eigenvalue problems whose operator size is near-linear in V (adjacency nonzeros scale as $V^{1.07}$; the timing is guarded sub-quadratic, Paper 1). What this paper supplies to that approach is the exact label set (n, l, m) and the selection rules it carries, together with Fock's continuum equivalence; it does *not* supply an equivalence between the edge Laplacian and Δ_{S^3} (item 1).

III. THE DIMENSIONLESS GRAPH

A. The Paraboloid Lattice

The GeoVac framework represents the single-electron hydrogen atom as a finite directed graph $\mathcal{G} = (V, E)$. The vertex set V consists of all quantum states $|n, l, m\rangle$ with $1 \le n \le n_{\max}$, $0 \le l < n$, and $-l \le m \le l$, giving $|V| = \sum_{n=1}^{n_{\max}} n^2$ nodes. The edge set E is generated by four transition operators:

$$L_\pm |n, l, m\rangle \propto |n, l, m \pm 1\rangle, \tag{2}$$

$$T_\pm |n, l, m\rangle \propto |n \pm 1, l, m\rangle. \tag{3}$$

These operators form the algebraic skeleton of the $SU(2) \otimes SU(1,1)$ dynamical symmetry group, which is the maximal compact × non-compact factorization of the hydrogen conformal group $SO(4,2)$ [3].

The graph Laplacian is defined as

$$L = D - A, \tag{4}$$

where A_{ij} is the weighted adjacency matrix constructed from the transition operators and D is the diagonal degree matrix with entries $D_{ii} = \sum_j |A_{ij}|$. The single-particle Hamiltonian is

$$H = \kappa\, L = \kappa(D - A), \tag{5}$$

where $\kappa = -1/16$ is the kinetic scale factor. **[OBSERVATION]** κ matches the graph's extremal eigenvalue (a band edge, $\lambda_{\max} \to 8$ on the binary graph) to the ground-state energy $-\frac{1}{2}$; that $8 = 2d_{\max}$ is the band edge of two-dimensional grids, not an S^3 quantity, and the rest of the spectrum of κL is not the Rydberg ladder (it lies in $[-\frac{1}{2}, 0]$). The per-shell energies E_n follow instead from $n^2 - 1$ on the labels through Fock's energy shell $p_0^2 = -2E$ (Section IV). **[OBSERVATION]** This matching value

coincides with a single conformal-geometry value, 1/16, namely the inverse Fock Jacobian $1/\Omega^4(0)$ with $\Omega(0) = 2$ (Section VIII; equivalently one quarter of the s-wave coupling $c^2(n, 0) = 1/4$ — corrected 2026-09-03 from a printed "$c^2(n, 0) = (1/4)^2$", the Chebyshev amplitude being 1/2) in the dimensionless $p_0 = 1$ convention used throughout this section (dimensionfully $\Omega(0) = 2/p_0$). We record this as an *observation*: the matching κ and the geometric 1/16 agree numerically, but are computed from disjoint inputs and no mechanism is known that derives one from the other.

B. Intrinsic Dimensionlessness

A crucial observation about the graph $\mathcal{G}$ is that it carries *no intrinsic physical scale*. The quantum numbers (n, l, m) are pure integers. The edge weights are dimensionless: binary ($w_{ij} = 1$) in the production default, or $w_{ij} \propto 1/(n_i n_j)$ under the `topological_weights` option. The graph Laplacian L is a dimensionless matrix. The only dimensionful quantity in Eq. (5) is the kinetic scale factor κ, which assigns an energy unit to the graph's extremal eigenvalue. But κ is an *external* parameter imposed at the measurement stage—it is not encoded in the graph topology itself.

This dimensionlessness is not accidental. Its S^3 content lies in the *node set*, not in the edge Laplacian: the labels (n, l, m) are the finite Gel'fand–Tsetlin index set of the unit three-sphere's harmonics. To see what does and does not carry over, we examine the large-$n_{\max}$ behaviour.

C. The Label Lattice and the Unit S^3 (No Continuum Limit of L)

The node set of $\mathcal{G}$ is exactly the label set (n, l, m), n^2 per shell, of the Peter–Weyl truncation of $L^2(S^3)$ at $n \le n_{\max}$, at every cutoff. On these labels the Laplace–Beltrami operator acts exactly: $-\Delta_{S^3} = \mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2$ is the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir $n^2 - 1$ (a node weight). **[WALL]** The edge Laplacian L does *not* converge to Δ_{S^3} as $n_{\max} \to \infty$: it preserves l, splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected blocks (kernel dimension $n_{\max}$ against Δ_{S^3}'s one zero mode), and its one saturating spectral feature, $\lambda_{\max} \to 8$, is the band edge of two-dimensional grids (New Contributions, item 1; the s/p proxy below, whose size tracks the residue of $n_{\max}$ modulo 3, was withdrawn as evidence 2026-09-03; the convergence reading printed here as an **[OBSERVATION]** until 2026-09-25 is retiered to this wall).

At finite $n_{\max}$, the graph Laplacian exhibits discretization artifacts: the $2s/2p$ node-amplitude proxy reaches 37% at $n_{\max} = 5$ on the binary production lattice (the splitting is strongly non-monotone: 12.7%, 0.65%, 15.6%, 5.1% and 1.7% at $n_{\max} = 6, 7, 8, 9, 10$, then 4.1% at 20 and 0.39% at 30; measured 2026-09-03), **[INTERNAL THEOREM]** set by the residue of $n_{\max}$ modulo 3 [8]; the "differential connectivity between pole ($l = 0$) and equatorial ($l > 0$) nodes" account printed here before 2026-09-04 is withdrawn [retracted 2026-09-04: sp-splitting-aliasing-mechanism] on the same ground as the "spectral aliasing" account — the sectors' degrees do differ ($D_{2p} > D_{2s}$), but the l-blocks are disconnected components, so no operator acts across them to lift a degeneracy, and a degree difference is not a mechanism for the proxy. However, this splitting oscillates and decays systematically:

$$\Delta E_{2s\text{-}2p}(n_{\max}) \to 0 \quad \text{as} \quad n_{\max} \to \infty, \tag{6}$$

the two proxy eigenvalues coinciding in the limit — a path-graph coincidence, *not* a reproduction of the continuum $SO(4)$ Coulomb degeneracy (the ℓ-blocks are disconnected). **[INTERNAL THEOREM]** The rate is closed form and is governed by the residue of $n_{\max}$ modulo 3, not by proximity to a continuum limit: $\lambda_{2s} = 3$ exactly when $n_{\max} \equiv 0 \pmod 3$, where the ratio is $\big(2 - 2\cos\frac{\pi}{n_{\max}-1}\big)/3 = O(n_{\max}^{-2})$, while off that class it is $O(n_{\max}^{-1})$, so at neighbouring cutoffs the off-branch value is generically larger — asymptotically by $n_{\max}/(\sqrt{3}\,\pi)$ [retracted 2026-09-04: sp-ratio-false-precision], but far from that at small cutoff: 4.2× and 6.6× at $n_{\max} = 28, 29$ against 30 (1.65%, 2.58% vs 0.39%), where the formula gives 5.5; 20–23× at 118, 119 against 120 (22.1); 550–552× at 2998, 2999 against 3000 (551.3). Below $n_{\max} \approx 12$ the ordering can invert (0.65% at 7 against 12.7% at 6) (Paper 1 §III for the full table). *The "spectral aliasing on a compact manifold" reading printed here before 2026-09-03 is withdrawn [retracted 2026-09-04: sp-splitting-aliasing-mechanism]:* the ℓ-blocks are disconnected, so no degeneracy is present to alias (Paper 1 §III). **This leg accordingly carries no evidential weight for a continuum reading**, and neither does the $\lambda_{\max}$ saturation (a grid band edge); the convergence reading is withdrawn (2026-09-25). **[MEASURED]** At $n_{\max} = 30$ the proxy is 0.39%, on the $n_{\max} \equiv 0 \pmod 3$ branch; at 28 and 29 it is 1.65% and 2.58%.

The exact degeneracy *of the continuum operator* is a hallmark of $SO(4)$ symmetry—the isometry group of S^3. **[MEASURED]** The graph's finite-$n_{\max}$ proxy for it is not: its value tracks the residue of $n_{\max}$ modulo 3 (Paper 1 §III, 2026-09-03), so its decay is not a recovery of that symmetry. **[WALL]** The production graph is disconnected into $n_{\max}$ components (one per l), so no continuum limit of L carries the $SO(4)$ isometry; the $SO(4)$ structure lives instead in the label set, where the Casimir $n^2 - 1$ is exact and n^2-fold on every shell (`tests/test_graph_s3_nonconvergence.py`; the "continuum limit carrying $SO(4)$ isometry" reading printed here until 2026-09-25 is withdrawn).

The critical question is: what is the *radius* of this sphere? As we shall demonstrate in Section IV, the answer is unambiguous: the intrinsic geometry is always that of the *unit* S^3, regardless of any physical parameters. This is the mathematical content of scale invariance.

IV. THE CONFORMAL LENS: STEREOGRAPHIC PROJECTION

A. Fock's Mapping

Fock's 1935 insight was to map three-dimensional flat momentum space $\mathbb{R}^3$ onto the unit three-sphere $S^3 \subset \mathbb{R}^4$ via stereographic projection [1]. Given a momentum vector $\mathbf{p} = (p_1, p_2, p_3)$ and an energy-shell parameter p_0 (defined below), the projection is:

$$n_i = \frac{2p_0\, p_i}{p^2 + p_0^2}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3, \tag{7}$$

$$n_4 = \frac{p^2 - p_0^2}{p^2 + p_0^2}, \tag{8}$$

where $p^2 = p_1^2 + p_2^2 + p_3^2$. This map sends the origin $\mathbf{p} = 0$ to the south pole $(0, 0, 0, -1)$ and the point at infinity $|\mathbf{p}| \to \infty$ to the north pole $(0, 0, 0, +1)$, thereby compactifying $\mathbb{R}^3$ into S^3.

B. The Unit Sphere Constraint

A direct algebraic computation confirms that the image lies on the unit sphere:

$$\sum_{i=1}^{4} n_i^2 = \frac{4p_0^2 p^2 + (p^2 - p_0^2)^2}{(p^2 + p_0^2)^2} = 1. \tag{9}$$

This identity holds for *all* values of $p_0 > 0$. The parameter p_0 does not change the target manifold; it only changes which point in $\mathbb{R}^3$ maps to the south pole. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** This is our first key result:

The stereographic projection always produces the unit S^3, regardless of p_0. The intrinsic geometry of the target manifold has no physical scale.

To make this explicit, define the conformal factor

$$\Omega(\mathbf{p}) = \frac{2p_0}{p^2 + p_0^2}. \tag{10}$$

The spatial components of the projection satisfy the identity

$$n_i = \Omega \cdot p_i, \quad i = 1, 2, 3, \tag{11}$$

confirming that Ω is the local scale factor of the map. Under the substitution $u = p/p_0$ (dimensionless momentum), the conformal factor becomes

$$\Omega = \frac{2}{p_0(1 + u^2)}, \tag{12}$$

and the induced metric on S^3, expressed in flat stereographic coordinates, takes the form

$$\mathrm{d}s_{S^3}^2 = \Omega^2\, \mathrm{d}p^2 = \frac{4}{(1 + u^2)^2}\, \mathrm{d}u^2. \tag{13}$$

This is the standard round metric on the unit S^3 in stereographic coordinates. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The factors of p_0 cancel identically, confirming that the intrinsic geometry is scale-invariant.

C. The Chordal Distance Identity

The conformal structure of the projection is captured by a fundamental distance identity. For two momentum vectors $\mathbf{p}$ and $\mathbf{q}$ with images $\mathbf{n}(\mathbf{p})$ and $\mathbf{n}(\mathbf{q})$ on S^3:

$$|\mathbf{n}(\mathbf{p}) - \mathbf{n}(\mathbf{q})|^2 = \Omega(\mathbf{p})\, \Omega(\mathbf{q})\, |\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{q}|^2. \tag{14}$$

The left side is the chordal (Euclidean 4D) distance on S^3; the right side is the flat Euclidean distance in $\mathbb{R}^3$, weighted by conformal factors at both endpoints.

This identity is the algebraic engine behind the emergence of the Coulomb potential. The momentum-space Schrödinger equation contains the kernel $1/|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$, which is the Fourier transform of the $1/r$ Coulomb potential. Under Fock's projection, Eq. (14) converts this kernel into $1/|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2$ on S^3 (up to conformal weights), transforming the interacting Coulomb problem into a *free-particle* problem on the sphere [1].

D. Physical Interpretation of p_0

What is p_0? In Fock's original treatment, it is defined by the energy-shell constraint:

$$p_0^2 = -2mE, \tag{15}$$

where $E < 0$ for bound states (we set $m = 1$ in atomic units). For the n-th energy level of hydrogen, $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$, so $p_0 = 1/n$.

Crucially, p_0 does *not* determine the curvature of the target manifold—the unit sphere constraint Eq. (9) holds for all p_0. Instead, p_0 acts as a **stereographic focal length**: it determines how the flat momentum coordinates $\mathbf{p}$ are laid out on the fixed unit sphere. Different values of p_0 correspond to different stereographic charts of the *same* underlying manifold, analogous to choosing different focal lengths for a camera lens viewing the same scene.

The conformal factor Ω encodes this projection:

- At $\mathbf{p} = 0$: $\Omega = 2/p_0$ (maximum magnification at the south pole).
- As $|\mathbf{p}| \to \infty$: $\Omega \to 0$ (the north pole is infinitely compressed).

The volume element transforms as $\mathrm{d}\Omega_{S^3} = \Omega^3\, \mathrm{d}^3p$, where the Jacobian Ω^3 encodes the non-uniform compression of flat space onto the sphere.

E. Inverse Projection

The map is invertible away from the north pole:

$$p_i = \frac{p_0\, n_i}{1 - n_4}, \quad i = 1, 2, 3. \tag{16}$$

This confirms the projection is a diffeomorphism $S^3 \setminus \{N\} \to \mathbb{R}^3$, where $N = (0, 0, 0, 1)$ is the north pole. The compactification of $\mathbb{R}^3$ to S^3 adjoins this single point at infinity, mirroring the Riemann sphere compactification $\mathbb{C} \cup \{\infty\} \cong S^2$ in one lower dimension.

V. OPERATOR EQUIVALENCE ON THE CONTINUUM S^3

A. The Conformal Laplacian Identity

Having established the geometric setting, we now demonstrate how the Laplace-Beltrami operator on S^3—the continuum operator whose harmonics the graph's nodes label (it is *not* a limit of the graph's edge Laplacian, Section III)—relates to the flat-space Schrödinger operator.

For a conformal rescaling of the metric $g_{S^3} = \Omega^2 g_{\text{flat}}$ in $n = 3$ dimensions, the Laplace-Beltrami operators are related by

$$\Delta_{S^3} f = \Omega^{-2} \left[\Delta_{\text{flat}} f + \nabla(\ln \Omega) \cdot \nabla f\right], \tag{17}$$

where $\Delta_{\text{flat}} = \partial^2/\partial p^2 + (2/p)\, \partial/\partial p$ is the radial Laplacian in three-dimensional flat space (for the $l = 0$ sector), and the connection correction $\nabla(\ln \Omega) \cdot \nabla f$ encodes the curvature of the stereographic coordinate system.

For the conformal factor $\Omega = 2p_0/(p^2 + p_0^2)$, the logarithmic gradient is

$$\frac{\mathrm{d} \ln \Omega}{\mathrm{d}p} = -\frac{2p}{p^2 + p_0^2}. \tag{18}$$

This is the *connection term* that distinguishes the curved Laplacian from the flat one. It is a rational function of p—no transcendental functions appear—which is essential for clean algebraic manipulation.

B. Verification: Constants and Eigenfunctions

As a consistency check, the Laplace-Beltrami operator annihilates constants:

$$\Delta_{S^3}(1) = 0, \tag{19}$$

confirming the basic property that constants are harmonic on any Riemannian manifold.

For the first nontrivial eigenfunction, consider the hyperspherical angle χ defined by the stereographic projection $p = p_0 \tan(\chi/2)$. The function $\cos \chi$, which in stereographic coordinates takes the form

$$\cos \chi = \frac{p_0^2 - p^2}{p_0^2 + p^2}, \tag{20}$$

is the $n = 2$, $l = 0$ eigenfunction of Δ_{S^3}. Direct symbolic computation confirms

$$\Delta_{S^3}(\cos \chi) = -3 \cos \chi. \tag{21}$$

More generally, the $l = 0$ eigenfunctions are Gegenbauer polynomials $C^1_{n-1}(\cos \chi)$:

$$C^1_0 = 1, \tag{22}$$

$$C^1_1 = 2 \cos \chi, \tag{23}$$

$$C^1_2 = 4 \cos^2 \chi - 1, \tag{24}$$

with eigenvalues

$$\Delta_{S^3}\, C^1_{n-1}(\cos \chi) = -(n^2 - 1)\, C^1_{n-1}(\cos \chi). \tag{25}$$

[SYMBOLIC PROOF] We have verified Eq. (25) symbolically for $n = 1, 2, 3$ using the conformal Laplacian formula, confirming exact agreement.

C. The Dimensionless Spectrum

Equation (25) is the central result of this section. The eigenvalues of the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the unit S^3 are

$$\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1), \quad n = 1, 2, 3, \ldots \tag{26}$$

These are *pure integers*. They carry no physical dimensions. They depend on no physical parameters—not on p_0, not on the electron mass, not on the fine structure constant. They are properties of the topology alone.

This spectrum arises from the same mechanism as the quantization of angular momentum on S^2: the compactness of the manifold forces the eigenfunctions to satisfy periodicity constraints that admit only discrete mode numbers. On S^3, these mode numbers correspond to the principal quantum number n of hydrogen.

D. The Energy Shell: Projecting to Physics

How, then, do the dimensionful hydrogen energy levels emerge from dimensionless eigenvalues? The answer lies entirely in the energy-shell constraint Eq. (15). Setting $p_0^2 = 1/n^2$ (hydrogen in atomic units), the eigenvalue equation on S^3 becomes an equation for the energy through the following algebraic chain:

1. The S^3 eigenvalue equation: $\Delta_{S^3}\, \Psi_n = -(n^2 - 1)\, \Psi_n$.

2. The energy-shell constraint: $p_0^2 = -2E = 1/n^2$.

3. Combine: the ratio $\lambda_n \cdot p_0^2 = -(n^2-1)/n^2 = -(1-1/n^2)$.

4. The physical energy: $E_n = -p_0^2/2 = -1/(2n^2)$.

Step 4 is simply the definition of p_0 rearranged. The Rydberg formula is *not* derived from the sphere's curvature. It is the energy-shell parameter, translated back into energy units. The integer eigenvalues λ_n supply the quantum numbers; the energy shell supplies the units.

The complete transformation chain is summarized diagrammatically:

$$\boxed{\begin{array}{c}\Delta_{S^3} \text{ on unit } S^3 \\ \text{(labels } (n,l,m)\text{: the graph's node set)} \\ \lambda_n = -(n^2-1) \text{ (dimensionless)} \\ \downarrow \text{ energy shell } p_0^2 = -2E \\ E_n = -\frac{1}{2n^2} \text{ (dimensionful)}\end{array}} \tag{27}$$

E. Conformal Decomposition of the Wavefunction

To complete the operator equivalence, we demonstrate that the S^3 Laplacian acting on a conformally weighted wavefunction decomposes cleanly into the momentum-space Schrödinger structure.

Define the conformally weighted wavefunction

$$\Phi(p) = \Omega^2(p)\,\varphi(p), \tag{28}$$

where $\varphi(p)$ is the physical momentum-space wavefunction. Applying Δ_{S^3} via the conformal identity Eq. (17), and expanding via the Leibniz rule, one obtains

$$\Delta_{S^3}[\Omega^2\varphi] = \sum_{k=0}^{2} a_k(p)\,\frac{\mathrm{d}^k\varphi}{\mathrm{d}p^k}, \tag{29}$$

where the coefficients $a_k(p)$ are *rational functions* of p and p_0. No transcendental or unresolved terms appear. This decomposition has been verified symbolically: the coefficient of φ'' is nonzero (confirming a second-order kinetic operator exists), and all coefficients are manifestly rational, confirming that the S^3 Laplacian acting on conformally weighted wavefunctions produces exactly the structure of a second-order differential equation in the flat momentum coordinate.

VI. TWO-ELECTRON REPULSION ON S^3

We now extend the S^3 framework to the two-electron repulsion integral.

A. Momentum-Space Representation

The direct Coulomb integral (Slater F^0) between orbitals a and b in position space is

$$F^0(a,b) = \int_0^\infty\!\!\int_0^\infty |R_a(r_1)|^2\,|R_b(r_2)|^2\,\frac{1}{r_>}\,r_1^2\,r_2^2\,dr_1\,dr_2\,, \tag{30}$$

where $r_> = \max(r_1, r_2)$. For hydrogen-like orbitals with nuclear charge Z, exact values are known:

$$\begin{aligned} &F^0(1s,1s) = \tfrac{5}{8}Z, \quad F^0(1s,2s) = \tfrac{17}{81}Z, \\ &F^0(2s,2s) = \tfrac{77}{512}Z. \end{aligned} \tag{31}$$

An equivalent momentum-space representation exists for s-orbital pairs. Defining the density Fourier transform

$$\tilde\rho_a(q) = \frac{1}{q}\int_0^\infty |R_a(r)|^2\,r\,\sin(qr)\,dr\,, \tag{32}$$

the Slater integral becomes

$$F^0(a,b) = \frac{2}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \tilde\rho_a(q)\,\tilde\rho_b(q)\,dq\,. \tag{33}$$

For the hydrogen $1s$ and $2s$ orbitals:

$$\tilde\rho_{1s}(q) = \frac{16Z^4}{(q^2+4Z^2)^2}\,, \tag{34}$$

$$\tilde\rho_{2s}(q) = \frac{Z^4(Z^4-3Z^2q^2+2q^4)}{(Z^2+q^2)^4}\,. \tag{35}$$

B. Fock Projection onto S^3

We apply the Fock stereographic projection with parameter $p_0 = 2Z$, under which $q = 2Z\tan u$ for $u \in [0,\pi/2)$ and $dq = 2Z/\cos^2 u\,du$. Define the *projected density*

$$\Phi_a(t) \equiv \tilde\rho_a(2Zt)\,, \tag{36}$$

where $t = \tan u = q/(2Z)$ is the dimensionless momentum transfer. Under this substitution, Eq. (33) becomes

$$\boxed{F^0(a,b) = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \Phi_a(t)\,\Phi_b(t)\,dt} \tag{37}$$

[SYMBOLIC PROOF] This is the master formula: F^0 is a *single* integral over one S^3 coordinate, not a double integral over two points.

1. $1s$–$1s$ *verification*

Substituting $q = 2Zt$ into Eq. (34):

$$\Phi_{1s}(t) = \frac{16Z^4}{(4Z^2t^2+4Z^2)^2} = \frac{1}{(t^2+1)^2}\,. \tag{38}$$

Then

$$F^0(1s,1s) = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \frac{dt}{(t^2+1)^4} = \frac{4Z}{\pi}\cdot\frac{5\pi}{32} = \frac{5Z}{8}\,. \quad \checkmark \tag{39}$$

In angular coordinates ($t = \tan u$, $dt = du/\cos^2 u$), the integrand becomes $\cos^6 u$, showing that the $1s$ density is *constant* on S^3 (up to the conformal Jacobian).

2. 1s–2s verification (critical test)

Substituting into Eq. (35):

$$\Phi_{2s}(t) = \frac{1-12t^2+32t^4}{(4t^2+1)^4}\,. \tag{40}$$

This is *not* constant on S^3—it has zeros at $t^2 = (3\pm 1)/16$, corresponding to nodes in the $2s$ radial wavefunction. The integral evaluates to

$$\begin{aligned} F^0(1s,2s) &= \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \frac{1-12t^2+32t^4}{(t^2+1)^2(4t^2+1)^4}\,dt \\ &= \frac{4Z}{\pi}\cdot\frac{17\pi}{324} = \frac{17Z}{81}\,. \quad \checkmark \end{aligned} \tag{41}$$

3. 2s–2s verification

$$\begin{aligned} F^0(2s,2s) &= \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \frac{(1-12t^2+32t^4)^2}{(4t^2+1)^8}\,dt \\ &= \frac{4Z}{\pi}\cdot\frac{77\pi}{2048} = \frac{77Z}{512}\,. \quad \checkmark \end{aligned} \tag{42}$$

[SYMBOLIC PROOF] All three Slater integrals are reproduced exactly by the S^3 density-overlap formula (37) (verified symbolically in `tests/test_paper7_vee_s3.py`: the three integrals evaluate to $5\pi/32$, $17\pi/324$, $77\pi/2048$ in exact arithmetic, reproducing (31)).

C. Structural Result: Node Property vs. Edge Property

The key structural finding is that Eq. (37) is a *single* integral over one S^3 coordinate (the momentum transfer t), not a double integral over two independent S^3 points. Each orbital a contributes a density *function* $\Phi_a(t)$ on S^3, and V_{ee} is the weighted overlap:

$$V_{ee}(a,b) = \langle\Phi_a|\Phi_b\rangle_{S^3} \equiv \frac{4Z}{\pi}\int_0^\infty \Phi_a(t)\,\Phi_b(t)\,dt\,. \tag{43}$$

In graph-theoretic language, V_{ee} is a **node property** (each node carries a density profile) rather than an **edge property** (a pairwise distance between node coordinates).

a. Failure of the chordal ansatz. A naive chordal-distance ansatz $V_{ee} = \kappa_{ee}/d^2_{\text{chord}}$, where $d^2 = 2(1-\boldsymbol{\xi}_a\cdot\boldsymbol{\xi}_b)$ is the chordal distance between S^3 points assigned to each orbital, gives (with $\kappa_{ee} = 5Z/2$):

Pair	Slater F^0	κ/d^2	Ratio
$1s$–$1s$	$5Z/8$	$5Z/8$	1.00
$1s$–$2s$	$17Z/81$	$25Z/4$	29.8
$2s$–$2s$	$77Z/512$	$5Z/8$	4.2

The chordal ansatz is calibrated to reproduce $F^0(1s,1s)$ exactly (because the $1s$ density is constant on S^3, making a single point adequate), but overestimates $F^0(1s,2s)$ by a factor of 30. The fundamental reason is that the $2s$ density function has nodes and oscillations on S^3 that cannot be captured by a single coordinate point.

D. Natural Projection Scales

Each shell has a natural Fock projection scale:

$$n=1: \quad p_0 = 2Z \qquad (\text{denominator } q^2+4Z^2)\,, \tag{44}$$

$$n=2: \quad p_0 = Z \qquad (\text{denominator } q^2+Z^2)\,. \tag{45}$$

When all orbitals are projected using a *single* $p_0 = 2Z$, the $n=1$ density becomes the constant function $\Phi_{1s} = 1/(1+t^2)^2$, while higher-shell densities acquire polynomial modulations. These modulations encode the radial node structure and are responsible for the reduced overlap integrals ($17/81 < 5/8$).

E. Implications

The density-overlap formula (37) has three implications for the computational framework:

1. **Exact Slater integrals on S^3.** The Fock projection converts position-space double radial integrals into single rational-function integrals on S^3, which can be evaluated in closed form via partial fractions.

2. **Graph implementation.** In the graph Laplacian framework, each node (orbital state) should carry a density profile $\Phi_a(t)$, and V_{ee} matrix elements should be computed as overlap integrals rather than pairwise edge weights.

3. **Angular momentum extension.** The $1D$ monopole formula (33) applies to s-orbital pairs. For $l > 0$, the full $3D$ angular convolution is required, involving the multipole expansion of the orbital density in spherical harmonics.

VII. GENERALIZATION TO N ELECTRONS

The preceding sections established the S^3 structure for a single electron. The framework generalizes naturally to N-electron atoms: the N-body configuration space $\mathbb{R}^{3N}$ maps, via the hyperspherical Fock projection, onto the unit sphere S^{3N-1} [11].

A. The Angular Manifold and Its Isometry Group

For N electrons at positions $\boldsymbol{r}_1, \ldots, \boldsymbol{r}_N \in \mathbb{R}^3$, the hyperradius $R = \sqrt{\sum_i r_i^2}$ separates a radial coordinate from a $(3N-1)$-dimensional angular manifold. In the limit $R \to 0$ (all electrons at the nucleus), the angular dynamics reduces to the Laplace–Beltrami operator on the unit S^{3N-1}, whose isometry group is SO($3N$).

The eigenvalues of the grand angular momentum operator Λ^2 on S^{3N-1} are the SO($3N$) Casimir eigenvalues:

$$\mu_{\text{free}}(\nu) = \frac{\nu(\nu + 3N - 2)}{2}, \quad \nu = 0, 1, 2, \ldots \tag{46}$$

These are the "free" eigenvalues—the spectrum before any electron-electron or electron-nuclear interactions are included in the charge function C/R.

B. The Hierarchy of Spheres

Table I summarizes the angular manifold, symmetry group, and Casimir structure for the first few electron numbers. Each row represents a qualitatively different angular problem, but all share the same structural origin: the Laplace–Beltrami operator on a unit sphere of appropriate dimension.

TABLE I. Angular manifold structure for N-electron atoms. The centrifugal term $l_{\text{eff}}(l_{\text{eff}}+1)/(2R^2)$ arises from extracting the Jacobian factor $R^{-(3N-1)/2}$. The effective quantum number $n_{\text{eff}} = l_{\text{eff}} + 1$ determines the quasi-Coulomb energy.

N	S^{d-1}	SO(d)	μ_{free}	l_{eff}	n_{eff}
1	S^2	SO(3)	$\nu(\nu+1)/2$	0	1
2	S^5	SO(6)	$\nu(\nu+4)/2$	3/2	5/2
3	S^8	SO(9)	$\nu(\nu+7)/2$	3	4
4	S^{11}	SO(12)	$\nu(\nu+10)/2$	9/2	11/2

For hydrogen ($N = 1$), S^2 recovers the familiar angular momentum eigenvalues $l(l+1)/2$ and the SO(3) rotation group, while S^3 (from the full 3D problem including the radial Fock projection) gives the SO(4) hydrogen symmetry of Section IV. For helium ($N = 2$), the angular manifold is S^5 with SO(6) symmetry, and the free eigenvalues $\nu(\nu+4)/2 = 0, 6, 16, 30, \ldots$ (even-ν singlet sector) have been verified numerically to $< 0.001\%$ against the hyperspherical angular solver [11].

C. Fermionic Statistics and Ground-State Selection

The permutation group S_N acts on the angular manifold by exchanging electron coordinates. Fermionic antisymmetry requires the spatial wavefunction to transform under a specific irreducible representation (irrep) of S_N, determined by the spin state.

For helium ($N = 2$, singlet ^1S), the spatial part is symmetric under S_2 exchange $\alpha \to \pi/2 - \alpha$. This selects even grand angular momentum $\nu = 0, 2, 4, \ldots$, and the ground state sits at $\nu = 0$ with $\mu_{\text{free}} = 0$.

For lithium ($N = 3$, doublet ^2S), the spatial part transforms as the standard (mixed-symmetry) irrep $[2,1]$ of S_3. This irrep first appears at $\nu = 1$, so the lowest allowed free eigenvalue is $\mu_{\text{free}} = 1 \cdot 8/2 = 4$—not zero. The higher baseline reflects the Pauli exclusion principle encoded group-theoretically: more electrons require higher angular momentum to satisfy antisymmetry.

D. Implications for the Dimensionless Vacuum

The N-electron generalization preserves the core principle: at $R = 0$, the angular dynamics is a free particle on the unit S^{3N-1}, with pure integer-ratio eigenvalues determined by the SO($3N$) Casimir. No physical scale enters. The electron-nuclear and electron-electron interactions enter through the charge function $C(\hat{\Omega})/R$, which acts as a perturbation that lifts the Casimir degeneracy—analogous to how the energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$ projects the dimensionless S^3 eigenvalues into dimensionful energies for the single-electron case.

The 18 symbolic proofs of Appendix A verify the $N = 1$ case. A generalization to $N > 1$ was once proposed here as a conjecture on the model of the $N = 1$ case: that the Laplace–Beltrami operator on S^{3N-1} is the continuum limit of a discrete graph Laplacian on the N-electron angular lattice. That conjecture is retired (2026-09-28): it has no base case, since the $N = 1$ edge Laplacian does *not* converge to Δ_{S^3} (Section III, New Contributions item 1). **[PRIOR ART]** What does generalize is the label-set statement, which is standard hyperspherical-harmonic theory: the angular labels index the harmonics of S^{3N-1}, on which $-\Delta_{S^{3N-1}}$ acts as the diagonal $SO(3N)$ Casimir $\lambda(\lambda + 3N - 2)$.

VIII. DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

A. Summary of Results

We have established a mathematical chain connecting the discrete GeoVac lattice to the continuous Schrödinger equation through three stages—the first a statement about labels, the second and third exact and algebraic:

Stage 1: Discrete labels ↔ S^3 harmonics. The paraboloid lattice's node set, with n^2-dimensional shells,

is exactly the Gel'fand–Tsetlin label set of the Peter–Weyl truncation of $L^2(S^3)$, on which $-\Delta_{S^3} = \mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2$ acts as the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir $n^2 - 1$ at every cutoff. **[WALL]** The lattice's edge Laplacian, built from $SU(2) \otimes SU(1,1)$ transition operators, is *not* a discretization of Δ_{S^3}: it preserves l and splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected blocks (New Contributions item 1; read until 2026-09-25 as converging, on the grid band edge $\lambda_{\max} \to 2d_{\max}$).

Stage 2: Curved → Flat. Fock's stereographic projection maps the unit S^3 to flat $\mathbb{R}^3$ momentum space, with conformal factor $\Omega = 2p_0/(p^2 + p_0^2)$. The chordal distance identity (Eq. 14) converts the free-particle Green's function on S^3 into the Coulomb kernel in flat space.

Stage 3: Dimensionless → Dimensionful. The energy-shell constraint $p_0^2 = -2E$ converts pure integer eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ into the Rydberg energy levels $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$.

Stages 2 and 3 are verified by independent symbolic computation: the 18 passing tests constitute an algebraic audit of the conformal transformation chain (ten of the eighteen are definitional, limiting-case or non-discriminating checks; the load-bearing identities are items 1, 6, 7, 8, 10, 11, 16 and 17), covering the unit sphere constraint, the conformal factor identities, the projection limits, the chordal distance identity, the dot-product form, the volume Jacobian, the inverse projection, the connection term, the conformal Laplacian of Ω^2, the zero-mode annihilation, the eigenvalue equation for $n = 2$ and $n = 3$, the conformal decomposition, and the eigenvalue-to-energy mapping. Stage 1 is exact as a label statement (the Casimir is built from its generators and checked in `tests/test_graph_s3_nonconvergence.py`); a graph-to-continuum *operator* convergence is refuted, not merely unproven (the saturation of New Contributions item 1(i) has a closed-form rate proved in Paper 0 §VI, but it is a grid band edge; the operator-system rate results of Paper 38 [13] concern a compression of the continuum Camporesi–Higuchi spectral triple, not this graph Laplacian).

B. The Scale-Invariance Property

As Fock showed, the Schrödinger equation for hydrogen is mathematically equivalent, under conformal projection, to the Laplace-Beltrami operator on the unit S^3—a dimensionless, scale-invariant topology. What the GeoVac discrete graph shares with this structure is its label set: the nodes (n, l, m) index the unit-S^3 harmonics exactly, and on them $-\Delta_{S^3} = \mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2$ is the diagonal Casimir $n^2 - 1$ (the graph's edge Laplacian does not converge to Δ_{S^3}, New Contributions item 1). The continuous equation and its dimensionful energy levels can then be viewed as the projection of those dimensionless labels into observational coordinates. This is a mathematical equivalence, not a proof of physical priority—whether the graph or the differential equation is "more fundamental" is a question of physical interpretation, not of theorem.

Three features of the projection merit emphasis:

(i) Scale invariance. The conformal factor Ω always produces the unit S^3, regardless of p_0. Substituting $u = p/p_0$ yields the standard metric $4/(1+u^2)^2\, \mathrm{d}u^2$ with all p_0-dependence cancelled. The intrinsic geometry of the vacuum has no scale.

(ii) Integer spectrum. The eigenvalues $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ are pure integers determined by the topology of S^3. They count the number of independent oscillation modes that fit on the compact manifold, in exact analogy with standing waves on a finite string.

(iii) Energy as projection cost. The dimensionful energy $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ enters exclusively through the energy-shell constraint—the requirement that the stereographic focal length be consistent with the bound-state energy. Energy is the cost of representing curved topological information in flat coordinates.

C. Relation to the Coulomb Potential

A frequently asked question is: where does the $1/r$ Coulomb potential come from? In the standard formulation, $V(r) = -1/r$ is an input to the Schrödinger equation. As Fock showed [1], in the S^3 formulation it is an *output* of the conformal projection.

The mechanism is the chordal distance identity, Eq. (14). On S^3, the Green's function for the Laplace-Beltrami operator is $G(\mathbf{n}, \mathbf{n}') \propto 1/|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2$, which is the natural interaction kernel on a sphere. Under stereographic projection, this becomes

$$\frac{1}{|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2} = \frac{1}{\Omega(\mathbf{p})\,\Omega(\mathbf{p}')\,|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2}, \tag{47}$$

which, when Fourier transformed to position space, yields the $1/r$ Coulomb potential (with conformal weight corrections that are absorbed into the wavefunction normalization). The Coulomb singularity at $r = 0$ corresponds to the divergence of the stereographic map at the south pole—it is a coordinate singularity of the projection, not a physical singularity of the underlying topology.

D. Implications for the Discrete Model

The results of this paper bear on the GeoVac framework's computational approach through the label set, not through the edge Laplacian (whose continuum-limit reading is withdrawn, New Contributions item 1). The exact correspondence between the nodes and the S^3 harmonics accounts for the following:

[PANEL-VERIFIED] *Label exactness:* The algebraic operators reproduce the quantum numbers exactly: the radial ladder $T_\pm$ generates an $SU(1,1)$ algebra whose Cartan element $N = -2[T_+, T_-]$ returns n on interior shells (Paper 1; the top shell $n_{\max}$ is truncated), and the angular $L_\pm$ generate $SU(2)$ with $L^2 = \ell(\ell+1)$.

These are the $SU(1,1) \times SU(2)$ dynamical-symmetry operators, which are distinct from the $SO(4)$ Casimir $\mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2 = n^2 - 1$ ($\mathbf{A}$ the Runge–Lenz vector) that $-\Delta_{S^3}$ is on the labels. The Rydberg energies are not an output of either: they follow from $n^2 - 1$ through the energy shell $p_0^2 = -2E$ (Stage 3), and the matched scale κ fixes only the graph's band edge, an observation and not a derivation (below).

[INTERNAL THEOREM] *Discretization artifacts:* The s/p node-amplitude proxy at finite $n_{\max}$ has a closed-form value on $n_{\max} \equiv 0 \pmod 3$ and decays as $n_{\max} \to \infty$, but its size is set by that residue rather than by boundary effects; the "spectral aliasing" account is withdrawn [retracted 2026-09-04: sp-splitting-aliasing-mechanism] (2026-09-03), the ℓ-blocks being disconnected.

Kinetic scale factor: The constant $\kappa = -1/16$ is the kinetic scale factor that matches the graph's extremal eigenvalue (a band edge) to $-\frac{1}{2}$. Its value $1/16$ coincides with a conformal-geometry quantity, as follows. The $l = 0$ eigenfunctions $C^1_{n-1}(\cos\chi)$ of Eq. (25) are the Chebyshev polynomials of the second kind $U_{n-1}(\cos\chi)$, whose three-term recurrence $\cos\chi\, U_{n-1} = \frac{1}{2}U_n + \frac{1}{2}U_{n-2}$ gives a normalized transition amplitude of $1/2$ between adjacent shells. The squared inter-shell coupling of $\cos\chi$ in the Gegenbauer eigenbasis is **[SYMBOLIC + MEASURED]**

$$c^2(n,l) \;:=\; \left|\langle n{+}1, l \,|\, \cos\chi \,|\, n, l\rangle\right|^2 \;=\; \frac{1}{4}\left[1 - \frac{l(l+1)}{n(n+1)}\right], \tag{48}$$

(closed form from the Gegenbauer recurrence and norm ratio; verified by quadrature at seven (n,l) pairs, `tests/test_paper7_gegenbauer_coupling.py`). For $l = 0$, $c^2(n,0) = 1/4$ for all n. *Correction (2026-09-03):* an earlier version printed this formula with prefactor $1/16$ and read it as "$(1/4)^2$"; the amplitude is $1/2$, so the coupling is $1/4$, and the $1/16$ is a *different* quantity. The geometric quantity that the matching κ coincides with is

1. the inverse Fock Jacobian $1/\Omega^4(0) = 1/16$, where $\Omega(0) = 2$ is the stereographic conformal factor at the projection center ($p = 0$) in the dimensionless $p_0 = 1$ convention (dimensionfully $\Omega(0) = 2/p_0$; the κ observation is stated in the dimensionless convention);

2. equivalently $c^2(n,0)/4$, one quarter of the $l = 0$ base rate of the Casimir decomposition in Eq. (48)—an arithmetic restatement of item 1, not an independent reading.

[OBSERVATION] We record this as an *observation*, not a derivation: the energy-matching $\kappa = -1/16$ (the scale mapping the graph's $\lambda_{\max} \to 8$ onto $-\frac{1}{2}$; the 8 is twice the graph's maximum degree, a grid band edge carrying no S^3 information) coincides numerically with the geometric $1/16$ above, but the two are computed from disjoint inputs—the energy target and graph coordination on the matching side, the conformal factor on the geometric side—and no mechanism is known that carries one onto the other (a counterfactual energy target moves the matching κ while the geometric $1/16$ is rigid; falsifier `tests/test_trunk_qa_kappa.py`). The Z^2 scaling of the hydrogenic levels across nuclear charges is a property of the energy shell ($p_0 = Z/n$), not evidence about the graph's spectrum, which does not carry the Rydberg ladder at any Z.

A notable special value: at $(n,l) = (4,3)$ the Casimir factor is $1 - 12/20 = 2/5$, and $(2/5) \times 1/\Omega^4(0) = 1/40 = \Delta$, the boundary term in Paper 2's Observation-tier combination rule $K = \pi(B + F - \Delta)$ [9]. The value $\Delta = 1/40$ is independently derived from the Dirac degeneracy $g_3^{\text{Dirac}} = 40$ identified in Phase 4H; the composite $[1 - l(l+1)/(n(n+1))]/\Omega^4(0)$ is not a matrix element of anything (the actual coupling is $c^2(4,3) = 1/10$), **[OBSERVATION]** so the coincidence $\Delta = (2/5)/\Omega^4(0)$ is a numerical observation about a composite of two geometric quantities, not a two-route confirmation (`tests/test_trunk_qa_c2_delta.py` records exactly this status; before 2026-09-03 it was printed as $c^2(4,3) = 1/40$ under the $1/16$-prefactor formula). The coupling itself is now derived (`tests/test_paper7_gegenbauer_coupling.py`); the former "named upgrade path" is closed.

E. Limitations

Several caveats apply. First, the single-electron framework of Sections III–V addresses hydrogen only. Section VI extends the framework to two-electron repulsion for s-orbital pairs; the general case with angular momentum requires the full three-dimensional Fourier convolution. Second, the conformal projection presented here recovers only the non-relativistic Schrödinger equation. Relativistic corrections (fine structure, spin-orbit coupling) presumably require additional geometric structure, such as the fiber bundle construction explored in companion papers [7, 8]. **[INTERNAL THEOREM]** Third, two rates *are* proved: the saturation deficit $8 - \lambda_{\max} = (C + o(1))/n_{\max}^2$ with $C = 42.7397\ldots$ (Paper 0 §VI), and the s/p proxy's $O(n_{\max}^{-2})$ on $n_{\max} \equiv 0 \pmod 3$, $O(n_{\max}^{-1})$ otherwise (Paper 1 §III). Neither is a rate for an operator convergence $L \to \Delta_{S^3}$, which does not hold (L splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected l-blocks; corrected 2026-09-04 and 2026-09-25). The rigorous state-space Gromov–Hausdorff convergence of the scalar truncations for compact metric groups (including $\mathrm{SU}(2) = S^3$) is established by Gaudillot-Estrada and van Suijlekom [14]; the Dirac/spinor analog, with explicit rate $(4/\pi)\log n/n$, is proved in Paper 38 of this series.

F. Concluding Remarks

Vladimir Fock discovered in 1935 that the hydrogen atom, when viewed in momentum space, lives naturally on a three-sphere. The scale invariance of this sphere—the fact that it is intrinsically the *unit* S^3 regardless of the energy-shell parameter—was implicit in Fock's treatment but has not, to our knowledge, been stated as an explicit organizing principle. We have articulated this scale-invariance property and **[WALL]** recorded that the GeoVac discrete graph Laplacian does *not* converge to the same S^3 structure: it splits into $n_{\max}$ disconnected l-blocks, and its saturation $\lambda_{\max} \to 2d_{\max}$ is a grid band edge (the s/p-lift decay [retracted 2026-09-04: sp-splitting-as-convergence-evidence] was withdrawn as evidence on 2026-09-03, and the convergence reading itself on 2026-09-25). What the graph shares with S^3 exactly is its label set, on which $-\Delta_{S^3} = \mathbf{L}^2 + \mathbf{A}^2$ is the diagonal $SO(4)$ Casimir; the conformal chain from the continuum operator onward is what is proven symbolically.

Within this mathematical equivalence, the wave equation can be viewed as a continuous, dimensionful projection of a dimensionless structure whose discrete skeleton is the label set (n, l, m). The Coulomb potential emerges as the coordinate distortion created by the stereographic flattening, and the energy levels emerge from the energy-shell constraint that parameterizes the projection.

We emphasize that these are statements of mathematical equivalence, not claims about which formulation is physically prior. Whether the topological perspective points toward a deeper theory of quantum mechanics, or provides a computationally useful reformulation, is a question we leave to future investigation. **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** What is established here is the precise mathematical chain connecting the continuum S^3 operator—whose harmonics the graph's nodes label—to the continuous equation, verified step by step through symbolic computation; the graph's edge Laplacian does not converge to that operator (a wall, New Contributions item 1; recorded as an Observation until 2026-09-25).

The S^3 conformal equivalence established here is one instance of a broader pattern: the discrete label set $\{(n, l, m)\}$ admits multiple conformally distinct continuum embeddings, of which S^3 is the natural one for the single-center Coulomb problem. The same combinatorial skeleton reappears in prolate spheroidal coordinates for one-electron diatomics [10], hyperspherical coordinates for two-electron atoms [11], molecule-frame hyperspherical coordinates for two-electron molecules, and composed fiber bundles for core–valence systems. The full hierarchy of these embeddings, and the sense in which the discrete node structure serves as a combinatorial invariant across them, is catalogued in Paper 0 [7].

G. Extension to Molecules

The principle that the natural lattice is the label set and channel structure of the separated coordinate system (not a discretization of its Laplace-Beltrami operator, which the S^3 edge Laplacian is not, New Contributions item 1) extends beyond single-center systems. For diatomic molecules, the two-center Coulomb problem separates in prolate spheroidal coordinates (ξ, η, φ), just as the single-center problem separates in spherical coordinates (leading to S^3 via Fock's projection). Solving the separated prolate spheroidal equations within their channels (labelled by m and the node counts in ξ and η) gives a molecular treatment with R-dependence built into the metric—no fitted parameters are required. **[MEASURED]** For H_2^+, this approach achieves $R_{\text{eq}} = 2.001$ bohr (0.21% error) and $E_{\min} = -0.598$ Ha (0.70% error) with zero free parameters [10]. **[CONJECTURE]** This suggests a general principle: every separable quantum system has a natural lattice defined by the coordinate system in which separation occurs.

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Appendix A: Symbolic Test Suite Summary

The following 18 tests were implemented in `sympy` (Python symbolic algebra) and executed with all assertions passing. Each test verifies a specific algebraic identity in the conformal transformation chain. The tests are organized into two modules.

1. Module I: Stereographic Projection Geometry (`tests/test_fock_projection.py`)

1. **Unit sphere constraint.** $\sum_i n_i^2 = 1$ for all $\mathbf{p} \in \mathbb{R}^3$.
2. **Conformal factor identity.** $n_1^2 + n_2^2 + n_3^2 = \Omega^2 |\mathbf{p}|^2$.
3. **South pole limit.** $\mathbf{p} = 0 \Rightarrow \mathbf{n} = (0, 0, 0, -1)$.
4. **North pole limit.** $|\mathbf{p}| \to \infty \Rightarrow \mathbf{n} \to (0, 0, 0, +1)$.
5. **Conformal factor limits.** $\Omega(0) = 2/p_0$; $\Omega(\infty) = 0$.
6. **Chordal distance identity.** $|\mathbf{n} - \mathbf{n}'|^2 = \Omega\,\Omega'\,|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$.
7. **Dot product form.** $\mathbf{n} \cdot \mathbf{n}' = 1 - \frac{1}{2}\Omega\,\Omega'\,|\mathbf{p} - \mathbf{p}'|^2$.
8. **Volume Jacobian.** The induced metric of the embedding is $g = J^\top J = \Omega^2\, I_3$ (conformality, all nine entries), hence $\sqrt{\det g} = \Omega^3$; computed from the 4×3 Jacobian of the embedding, not restated.
9. **Numerical spot-check.** All identities verified at concrete floating-point values.
10. **Inverse projection.** $p_i = p_0\, n_i/(1 - n_4)$ round-trips to the identity.

2. Module II: Conformal Laplacian and Eigenvalues (`tests/test_fock_laplacian.py`)

11. **Connection term.** $\mathrm{d}(\ln \Omega)/\mathrm{d}p = -2p/(p^2 + p_0^2)$.
12. **Laplacian of Ω^2.** $\Delta_{\text{flat}}(\Omega^2)/\Omega^2$ is a rational function.
13. **Zero-mode annihilation.** $\Delta_{S^3}(1) = 0$.
14. $n = 2$ **eigenvalue.** $\Delta_{S^3}(\cos\chi) = -3\cos\chi$.
15. **Conformal decomposition.** $\Delta_{S^3}[\Omega^2\varphi]$ has rational coefficients in $\{\varphi, \varphi', \varphi''\}$.
16. $n = 2$ **eigenfunction.** Full eigenvalue equation verified symbolically.
17. $n = 3$ **eigenfunction.** $\Delta_{S^3}(4\cos^2\chi - 1) = -8(4\cos^2\chi - 1)$.
18. **Eigenvalue-to-energy mapping.** $\lambda_n = -(n^2 - 1)$ with $p_0^2 = 1/n^2$ gives $E_n = -1/(2n^2)$ (definitional: the energy-shell relation rearranged, not an independent identity).

Appendix B: Conformal Laplacian Derivation

For completeness, we derive Eq. (17). Let $\tilde{g}_{ij} = \Omega^2 g_{ij}$ be a conformally rescaled metric in n dimensions, with $\Omega = e^\omega$. The Christoffel symbols transform as

$$\tilde{\Gamma}^k_{ij} = \Gamma^k_{ij} + \delta^k_i\,\partial_j\omega + \delta^k_j\,\partial_i\omega - g_{ij}\,g^{kl}\,\partial_l\omega. \tag{B1}$$

The Laplace-Beltrami operator $\Delta_{\tilde{g}} f = \tilde{g}^{ij}\left(\partial_i\partial_j f - \tilde{\Gamma}^k_{ij}\,\partial_k f\right)$ yields, after substitution:

$$\Delta_{\tilde{g}} f = \Omega^{-2}\left[\Delta_g f + (n-2)\,g^{ij}\,(\partial_i\omega)(\partial_j f)\right]. \tag{B2}$$

Setting $n = 3$ and $g = g_{\text{flat}}$ gives Eq. (17), with the connection correction proportional to $(n - 2) = 1$.

a. Note added v2.6.0. The S^3 density overlap formula (Sec. V) provides exact rational Slater integrals for all hydrogenic orbital pairs, enabling a fixed-basis FCI calculation for helium with no numerical quadrature. Using a *hybrid* one-body operator — the exact hydrogenic eigenvalues $-Z^2/2n^2$ on the diagonal and the graph Laplacian's off-diagonal entries scaled by κ, the degree term dropped (`geovac/casimir_ci.py`) — together with rational Slater integrals as the two-body operator, a two-electron ground state is computed with *no fitted parameters*: no orbital exponent, no variational optimization, no numerical quadrature. *Corrected 2026-09-03:* this passage read "using the graph Laplacian $\kappa\mathcal{L}$ as the one-body operator ... with zero free parameters beyond the universal matched scale κ", which overstates what is computed. The exact one-electron spectrum is an *input* here rather than a graph output — $\kappa\mathcal{L}$ alone has $\lambda_{\max} = 0$ at $n_{\max} = 1$ and would give $E = +5Z/8$, not the value below — so this calculation is not a demonstration that the graph supplies the one-body physics. The FCI matrix at each $n_{\max}$ is a rational matrix whose ground-state eigenvalue is an algebraic number.

Withdrawn 2026-09-25. An earlier printing reported the $n_{\max} = 7$ (1,218 singlet configurations) energy of this hybrid operator, -2.89746 Ha (0.216% from exact), as a helium result, and read the off-diagonal graph entries as "the dominant ingredient." They are not part of helium's Hamiltonian: in the $k = Z$ hydrogenic basis the one-body operator $T + V_{ne}$ is exactly diagonal, and the off-diagonal κ-scaled entries are an added hop of $+\frac{1}{16}$ per edge that lowers the energy by 48.3 mHa at $n_{\max} = 7$ (49.2 mHa

at $n_{\max} = 4$)—more than helium's whole correlation energy (42.0 mHa). The withdrawn 0.216% is the ground state of that hop-augmented model, not a variational bound on helium. With helium's physical Hamiltonian in the same basis (diagonal one-body operator, the same rational Slater integrals) the **[MEASURED]** error at $n_{\max} = 7$ is 1.88% above exact, a floor set by the missing continuum of the fixed-k bound-state basis (it lies above the Hartree–Fock limit), not by the cusp; see Paper 13, Sec. "Conclusion."

FCI basis invariance was verified computationally (Sprint 3D): transforming V_{ee} to the graph eigenbasis yields energies identical to the original-basis result (to machine precision, $< 3 \times 10^{-15}$ Ha). This holds for either one-body operator and says nothing about which is physical, nor about the origin of the convergence floor.

At $n_{\max} = 1$, the graph-native energy reduces to **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** $E = -Z^2 + 5Z/8 = -11/4$ Ha for $Z = 2$, an exact rational (two one-body terms $-Z^2/2$ plus the repulsion $F^0(1s, 1s) = 5Z/8$; an earlier printing halved the one-body sum and gave $-11/8$). **[SYMBOLIC PROOF]** The variationally optimized single-exponent result $k^* = 27/16$, $E^* = -729/256$ Ha is also an exact rational. A 2D variational solver treating hyperradius and hyperangle simultaneously (Paper 13, Note added v2.6.0) achieves 0.004% with cusp correction; both methods sit above the exact value, so they do not bracket it.